

Carcinogenicity and regulation of caramel colorings.

2- and 4-methylimidazoles are present as contaminants in caramel colorings manufactured with ammonia catalysts. Both contaminants have been shown to induce cancer in animals and may be present in caramel colorings in amounts that exceed federal guidelines. California requires warning notices on products that could lead to consumption of more than 30 micrograms per day. The US Food and Drug Administration should bar the use of excessively contaminated caramel coloring in food.